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Writing Seminar: Structuring Argument

In our first meeting we learned a useful model for thinking about the building blocks of individual arguments: **claims**, **grounds**, and **warrants**. In our second meeting, we thought about arranging these pieces within individual argumentative paragraphs. We asked about the benefits of placing our main argumentative claims **first** or **last**, in relation to the grounds that supported them and the warrants that served as explanation for that support. We nodded toward *index positions* and *transitions* as useful components of complex paragraphs – topics we will discuss further in the Winter quarter.

I will emphasize, about the technical work we have done so far, that the focus has been on individual paragraphs. We have diagnosed these pieces together! But the single-paragraph essay is a rare thing, indeed. Most commonly – this will come as no surprise – you will write papers as a series of related paragraphs, all in a row. For our third Writing Seminar this quarter, we will think about how to structure **multiple argumentative paragraphs in relation to one another**.

WHAT PAPERS AREN'T

Many students, for reasons that continue to baffle and dismay careful thinkers everywhere, are taught to write essays that follow a form akin to this:

Introduction: I am going to claim **thing** for reasons A, B, and C (and D, and E, etc. etc.).

Body paragraph #1: **Thing** is true because reason A.

Body paragraph #2: **Thing** is true because reason B.

.....

Body paragraph #whatever: **Thing** is true because reason Z.

Conclusion: See, **thing** is true!

Expecting to write an essay that follows this sort of pattern, you begin your writing process by deciding exactly what the **thing** is that you think about the subject matter at hand. That is, you decide first *what you want to say*. Then, **thing** firmly established, you go searching through available evidence for bits that seem to support your **thing**. Your approach looks something like this:

- (1) Read the prompt.
- (2) Think about what you want to say.
- (3) Decide what **thing** you want to argue.
- (4) Find evidence that support your **thing**.
- (5) Write a paper that says, “**thing** is true because of this evidence I found.”

Ok so this is a silly way of going about thinking and writing in the world, and don't worry, we are going to talk plenty about how to do better. That's the next section!

But notice – just notice! – that the ultimate product of this mode of writing *is a dirty, rotten, no-good lie*. It is not, in fact, the case that you think **thing** is true *because* you went and found difficult bits of evidence, thought through their implications, and discovered something interesting about your subject matter. In this scenario, you did EXACTLY THE OPPOSITE of that. You decided a thing was true, then retconned as much evidence as you could muster into a pre-formed position. Likely, if you followed this approach, you didn’t discover anything, and neither did your reader.

Put another way: the content of your paper is trying desperately to say, “if you really think about all this evidence I collected, you will come to accept **thing**.” But the structure of the paper actually screams, “You should accept **thing** because I say so, and incidentally here’s some evidence or whatever.” You might not be wrong? **Thing** could be true or interesting or revelatory. But you might be extremely wrong! **Thing** could be false or boring or tired. The paper itself doesn’t help decide much, after all. It is, in a word, *unpersuasive*.

WHAT PAPERS SHOULD BE

At this point, you might be thinking: “OK, Tom, sure, that might all be a little bit true sometimes, but it was also a little harsh, wasn’t it? I mean, how else are we supposed to write arguments except by making claims and defending them? You make a very normal strategy sound extremely bad!”

I do, and it’s a great question. If you can force yourself to ask that question – “ok but how do I *actually* make an argument, then!?” – you are way ahead of the game. Let’s think about some answers, starting with a more persuasive (and interesting!) approach to the writing process itself, e.g.:

- (1) Read the prompt.
- (2) Consider a few delimited pieces of evidence that seem pertinent to thinking about reasonable answers to the prompt.
- (3) Revisit those pieces of evidence.
- (4) Write a bit about one of them.
- (5) Write a bit about another.
- (6) Realize that you’ve just written two rather different pieces of argument.
- (7) Revisit further pieces of evidence that might be more pertinent to one another.
- (8) Write a bit about one of those.
- (9) Revise what you wrote in step 3 or 4 or both with your new evidence in mind.
- (10) Probably delete a whole paragraph, because it turns out everything is more complicated than you first realized; or at least rearrange your evidence to make your thoughts make sense.
- (11) Repeat steps (3) through (11) until you are no longer humanly capable of doing so.
- (12) Take a nap, I guess?

Let me hasten to say that this approach should not be taken as totally delimiting: you might know from the start that you want to discuss a specific piece of evidence, you might (miraculously) write two initial paragraphs that are both coherent and argumentatively distinct, you might even have a sort of idea about what you think about the prompt (something like a “thing”) that turns out not to have been nearly as wrong or blunt as it could have been – all of this because you are an intelligent, thinking being in the world, and you care about sense and accuracy and truth.

Still, you’ll notice two crucial features of the formula I’ve proposed.

- First, it is **recursive**: it asks you to return over and over again to the subject matter you are writing about, in order to assess evidence new and old from different perspectives.
- Second, it is **flexible**: it asks you to allow your evidence to guide your argument, rather than the other way around.

Of course, you are going to choose evidence that you are interested in. That’s great! But you have not chosen that evidence just because it seems to fit something you already decided. Your evidence inflects your argument, and your predetermined notions do not wholly overtake any subtleties contained within the evidence you’ve examined..

The approach I’m recommending might lead to a paper that looks something like this:

Introduction*

Body paragraph #1: Claim 1 from Evidence A.

Body paragraph #2: Claim 2 that builds off Claim 1 from Evidence B.

Body paragraph #3: Claim 3 that builds off Claim 2 from Evidence C.

...

Conclusion*

*[more on the content of introductions and conclusions in a later seminar!]

The essential difference between this model and the one I posited above is that your argument is structured to develop sustained analysis of a single, limited, interesting topic over time. Your paragraphs do not stand apart from one another, each supporting a single overarching **thing** in one monotonous way. Rather, an understanding of your subject matter emerges from close inquiry into *how your evidence works* and *what it accomplishes* – again, not as singular snippets of text, but in a complex weave of attention and argumentation.

Your paper does not adopt some arbitrary stance and then defend it! It does something of far more interest for your body of evidence. Moreover, it leads both you and your reader into a deeper appreciation for the subject matter at hand.

AN EXAMPLE, OUTLINED

For obvious reasons, I cannot provide, in this brief format, a full example of both a cookie-cutter notsogreat paper *and* a nuanced, super-developed, highly readable paper. A further problem emerges when aiming to choose academic examples, since of course they tend to be extremely long. (This is a product of professional pressures more than the mode of writing itself.) To split the difference, a bit, I am providing you with a short section of argument from a student essay on Marie de France's *Lanval* – with the **claims** and **evidence** delineated, and with **evidence** and explanatory materials minimized. You need not be familiar with the poem (although, you should know, it's *amazing*) in order to see how the argument builds, develops, and flows over time:

Lanval's amie's knowledge of the chivalric code allows her to perform the role of the lord whom Lanval owes fealty to, establishing a relationship based on female authority. Before Lanval meets his amie, she demonstrates her role as his master through her ability to summon him. While riding in the countryside to escape his loneliness as an outsider in King Arthur's court, Lanval meets two young women who tell him of a demoiselle who "bids [him to] come to her" (74). Lanval's amie is aware of the dynamic between a lord and his knight and uses this knowledge to create a female-dominated power structure by becoming his lord. Upon his amie's declaration of love, Lanval says "I will do all that you require; forsake all those I might desire, and never seek to part from you" (127-129). Lanval offers himself as his amie's servant and will carry out her bidding, just as a knight obeys his lord. Also, just as any good lord rewards his knights, the amie offers Lanval "gold and silver" in exchange for his service (142) unlike King Arthur, who ignores him. Lanval's amie's patronage reveals her ability to perform the chivalric lord's role. As a lord, she can give Lanval what Arthur cannot; wealth, attention, and romance. While friendly kisses were allowed between male court members, sodomy was believed to cause damnation, so Arthur could not have a romantic relationship with Lanval. In the amie's relationship with Lanval, she establishes herself as his master and is implicitly a better lord than Arthur because she satisfies Lanval's desire for recognition and romance.

Lanval's amie uses her lordly authority to develop a contractual relationship with Lanval which hinges on his discretion. She uses authoritative diction when establishing their relationship, saying "Friend...I admonish you--, command, beseech!" (143-144). Her ability to "command" Lanval to listen demonstrates her successful lordly performance because she knows that as her knight, he must obey her. The amie's authoritative diction also reflects the importance of chivalric contracts, and the severe consequences to breaching them, such as banishment, death, and dishonor. Lanval's amie warns, "Betray us, and you lose your lover; I shall be lost to you for ever, lost to your sight; lost, our amours" (146-149). She conveys the eternal consequences of violating her rules with the repetition of "lost" to emphasize Lanval's permanent isolation if he fails to "obey" his lord (151). Lanval's amie's chivalric knowledge allows her to create a female-dominated power structure by becoming the lord who gives Lanval wealth and love in exchange for his obedience.

Similarly, Guinevere uses her chivalric knowledge to exert power over Lanval, first by attempting to seduce him, and then by telling Arthur that he dishonored her, violating the chivalric code. At a court party, Guinevere notices that Lanval is not flirting with the female guests like a good knight should. In a reversal of courtly behavior, this damsel attempts to seduce the knight by saying, "Freely, I give you my druerie, you must rejoice in taking me!" (267-268). This reversal reflects Guinevere's knowledge of chivalric dynamics, which allows her to perform the seductive knight's role in an attempt to gain power over Lanval. Guinevere is unaware that Lanval is rejecting her because he is protected by another chivalric figure, his lord-like amie, so she implies that he must prefer "well-trained young men" (281). Guinevere's insinuation that Lanval is homosexual also reflects her chivalric knowledge, understanding that homosexuality "deviate[s] from the normative gender behavior and 'proper' direction of desire," and tries to use it to gain an advantage over Lanval. If he were homosexual, this claim would shift the power dynamic in Guinevere's favor; her chivalric performance and presumed heterosexuality would be closer to the knight's ideal behavior. Because of Guinevere's accusation, Lanval rudely rejects her while revealing his amie:

"...some servant girl she has at hand, / the poorest in her retinue, / is, Lady Queen, worth more than you / in beauty—body and in face / in breeding, virtue, goodness, grace!" (298-302)

Lanval's disrespectful tone towards Guinevere and violation of his amie's contract reflects the dual breakage of the chivalric code, and his failings as a knight. He cruelly says that Guinevere is inferior to his amie's plainest servant, which contradicts the knight's duty to treat women respectfully. Guinevere uses Lanval's poor behavior to convince Arthur to put him on

trial, claiming that Lanval dishonored her by attempting to seduce her and then boasted about his beautiful “lover”. Guinevere’s chivalric knowledge is also evident through her successful performance as the humiliated victim; she is aware of the consequences of dishonorable behavior for knights and plays on Arthur’s emotions by crying at his feet when telling her tale (315).

Lanval’s amie uses his breached contract to “banish” him from her life. Her rejection of Lanval reflects the power she gained from performing the chivalric lord’s role. She is not swayed by Lanval’s “wailings, shouts, and cries” (347) because he is no longer worthy of being in her presence. As contractual violations often result in death or banishment, his amie further demonstrates her awareness of lordly behavior and the consequences of violating contracts by ignoring Lanval’s pleas, effectively banishing him from her love and causing him great emotional distress. Both Guinevere and Lanval’s amie use their chivalric knowledge to punish Lanval for his knightly failures, and readers can see they are superior chivalric agents.

While doing some disservice to the original argument, we can extrapolate an outline much like the formulas I provided above:

Body paragraph #1: Lanval’s lover uses the chivalric code to her social advantage.

Body paragraph #2: In her mastery over Lanval, Lanval’s amie creates a female-dominated power-structure, adopting the position of lord.

Body paragraph #3: Similarly [to Lanval’s amie], Guinevere uses the chivalric code to her own social advantage over Lanval.

Body paragraph #4: Both Lanval’s amie and Guinevere use their advantages to exert power over and punish Lanval for his knightly failures.

I want to stress that this is by no means a perfect essay! It tends, a bit, towards over citation, and it makes a few assumptions about medieval chivalric expectations that do not quite align with scholarly consensus on the genre. It nevertheless conducts a careful examination of two comparable hierarchies, both with powerful female agents at the top and Lanval at the bottom. Its argument is not groundbreaking – similar arguments about the poem have been made before and will be made again! – but it is nevertheless exemplary of the kind of structure you might strive for.

The claims are clearly related to one another, and in fact build on each other over time. They do not simply repeat the same idea four times in a row. (“Lanval stands at the bottom of a social hierarchy. Lanval stands at the bottom of a social hierarchy. Lanval stands at the bottom of a social hierarchy. Lanval stands at the bottom of a social hierarchy.....”)

By the end of these paragraphs, we have not lost sight of the original topic (hierarchy as established by facility with chivalric code), but we have nevertheless come to understand something about how that topic functions and where its terms might break down. We see, in the end, that the titular knight of his own poem is the least knightly character within – and we see precisely how that conclusion is made. This paper is *persuasive*.

Write persuasive papers!

ASSIGNMENT:

Your assignment for this week has three parts:

1. **Before completing part 3.** Read this informational sheet, or watch the corresponding video lecture, or both.
2. **No later than 48hrs before your seminar meeting.**
 - a. Locate your Canvas Group and its corresponding Google Document for this meeting.
 - b. Upload the work you submitted for Exercise 2 to the Google Document.
3. **Before your seminar meeting begins.**
 - a. Skim all of the materials that your peers have submitted.
 - i. You should be able to say, in broad terms, what each of your peers is writing about.
 - b. Respond to the essay for which you have been designated lead respondent.
 - i. First, read the essay in full,
 - ii. Then, for each *argumentative paragraph* (not the introduction or conclusion) **highlight the main point in yellow.**
 - iii. At the bottom of the paper, write a quick paraphrase of each main point in order.
 1. For an example, see my summary of the *Lanval* essay, given above.
 - iv. Does this paper develop a single idea over the course of its development?
 1. Are there paragraphs where nearly identical arguments are repeated?
 2. Are there paragraphs that appear unrelated?
 3. What paragraph, in your view, presents the most compelling argument about the evidence it presents?
 - v. You might also write a brief note to your peer – you may be direct, but please also be kind.